

1258-IMM498-02: PSYCHOLOGY OF ETHICS

An Ethical Lens on the Kardashian-Jenner Empire

Jennèa (JJ) Jeter | January 23, 2026

Introduction

The Kardashian-Jenner (abbreviated as “Karjenner”) family is frequently dismissed as a pop culture phenomenon, with no other major reality television family or show able to outscore their ratings.

However, a psychological and ethical analysis reveals the family as a calculated machine, built on the commodification of private dysfunction and people’s desire to watch. The family does not survive *despite* these many controversies; it survives because of them. They utilize a unique recurring cycle of "scandal, silence, rebrand, and relaunch" to maintain cultural and financial relevance, transforming a household into an unquestionable American empire.

The ethical conflict at the core of the Karjenner business strategy is the process of manufacturing or exploiting controversy to maintain profit. This strategy often comes at the expense of stakeholders, including family members’ mental health and the financial well-being of their consumer base. By analyzing their history through the lens of organizational psychology (1), it becomes clear that their success is driven by four specific mechanisms:

1. Vroom’s Expectancy Theory
2. Bandura’s Moral Disengagement
3. Slippery Slope & Ethical Fading
4. and the “Bad Barrel” Environment

The landscape of the Karjenner empire has changed over the last two decades, making it necessary to examine the "business model" across its four distinct phases. With each one focused on a new sibling and a new era, these phases demonstrate how the family's strategy shifted from survival to dominance, often disregarding ethical boundaries.

Timeline Analysis:

The Blueprint Era (Late 90s – 2010)

The foundation of the empire was laid long before the reality show aired. This phase established the "Kris Jenner Blueprint," characterized by the monetization of private indiscretions. It began with Kris Jenner's history of infidelity and manipulation during her marriage to Robert Kardashian, an attorney and businessman, with his most notable case being defending O.J. Simpson during the 1995 trial.

However, amid the controversy over Kim Kardashian's 2007 tape with Ray J, the family capitalized on the exposure, turning shame into profit. Only in November 2025 would Ray J sue Kim and Kris, alleging that Kris Jenner had personally orchestrated the release of the tape and used the "leak" to boost their careers.

The Imperial Era (2010 – 2020)

As the brand emerged from this initial scandal, the family sought to move past its reality-TV roots.

Largely orchestrated by Kanye West in 2012, he overhauled the family's image, trading their tabloid status for high-fashion legitimacy and securing Kim's first Vogue cover in 2014. With this growth, the family's predatory monetization strategies intensified into a long string of early business ventures. One of these was the launch of the "Kardashian Kard" (2010), a prepaid card targeting teens with exorbitant fees that was quickly pulled after political outcry (2).

Simultaneously, the family began using internal dynamics for ratings, initially focusing on the only brother in the group, Rob Kardashian. The family mocked his weight, aired his therapy sessions, and focused episodes on his mental health spirals for television storylines. Following the shame-to-profit strategy that Kris Jenner had learned from Kim's tape, it proved that no member was safe from the growing commodification.

King Kylie Era (2014 — 2016)

This smaller phase was the only one in which Kim Kardashian was not the dominant figure, indicating a temporary shift in business toward the exploitation and commodification of the younger generation. The family narrative focused on 17-year-old Kylie Jenner's transformation after her relationship with the 24-year-old rapper Tyga. The normalization of a relationship between these for publicity paid off in exposure and profit. However, this phase would close out once the family faced allegations of business malpractice, most notably the inflation of Kylie's wealth to achieve Forbes billionaire status. Forbes eventually had the title retracted, stating that they had likely forged tax returns (3).

The Modern Era (2020 — Current Day)

The most recent phase is defined by "tone-deafness" and a disregard for the general public. One of the larger-scale scandals was the Astroworld tragedy (2021), during which Kylie and Kendall posted from the concert while ambulances moved through the crowd to reach victims (4). Compounding this was the public unraveling of Kanye West, whose worsening mental condition and antisemitic rhetoric created another PR crisis against the family's carefully curated image. This era also includes Kim's infamous "Get your ass up and work" comments, further alienating the working-class audience that built their wealth.

Application of Ethical Theories:

1. Vroom's Expectancy Theory (Motivation)

To understand why the family continues to pursue negative publicity despite the pattern established in the phases above, one can apply Vroom's Expectancy Theory, in which motivation is determined by three factors: *Valence, Instrumentality, and Expectancy* (1).

- **Valence:** The family places an exceptionally high value (valence) on fame, relevance, and wealth. This intense desire for the reward drives the behavior.
- **Instrumentality:** The belief that a specific performance will lead to a specific reward. The Kardashians learned in Phase 1 that scandal (performance) leads directly to profit (reward). The release of the tape resulted in a reality TV contract, and bad press often results in higher ratings.
- **Expectancy:** Due to their financial power, they possess a high level of confidence (expectancy) that they can successfully manipulate the media cycle to achieve these results.

Because the "instrumentality" is so strong, the link between bad behavior and financial gain is repeatedly reinforced, with no motivational incentive to behave ethically.

2. Mechanisms of Moral Disengagement

The family frequently uses Moral Disengagement, as noted by Albert Bandura, a cognitive restructuring that allows individuals to behave unethically without feeling personal distress.

- **Distortion of Consequences:** This mechanism allows individuals to ignore or minimize the harm their actions cause. The Astroworld tragedy shows that, by prioritizing brand maintenance over the reality of human loss, the family demonstrated a "distortion of consequences" and failed to meet its ethical obligations to the victims.
- **Dehumanization:** The family often protects their brand by dehumanizing those who threaten it. When Tristan Thompson cheated on Khloe Kardashian with Jordyn Woods, the family publicly targeted 21-year-old Woods online, while Thompson (the actual partner) received significantly

less public wrath. The incident only ceased after Kylie cried during the show: "I just don't think anyone deserves this" (5). By framing Woods as an enemy, they justified bullying behavior that would otherwise be considered a violation of moral norms.

3. The Slippery Slope and Ethical Fading

The concept of the "Slippery Slope" suggests that small unethical acts pave the way for larger transgressions. This is often facilitated by Ethical Fading, occurring when the moral aspects of a decision fade from view, leaving only the "business" or "financial" decision visible.

- The Slope: The behavior escalated from minor reality-TV fakery in The Origins to serious deception in the King Kylie Era. It began with "selling out" siblings for plotlines and evolved into allegations of financial fraud involving tax returns.
- Fading in Action: As the empire grew, the family appeared to become "numb" to the moral implications. The decision to release a predatory credit card for teens was likely not viewed by them as "exploiting children," but simply as "licensing a product." The ethical coloring of the decision had faded, leaving only the profit margin in sight.

4. The "Bad Barrel" Environment

A recurring theme in the Karjenner family is the concept of the "Bad Apple" (a corrupt individual) and consequent "Bad Barrel" (a corrupt environment). While it is easy to point to Kris Jenner as a specific "Bad Apple," the analysis suggests she created a "Bad Barrel" ecosystem (1).

In this environment, family members are treated as commodities rather than people. The norms established within the family unit prioritize the collective brand over individual well-being. This creates a

closed loop where unethical behavior is not only tolerated but rewarded, making it difficult for any single family member to break the cycle without risking their status and income.

Conclusion

The Kardashian-Jenner legacy is defined by the ability to weaponize monetization and revisionist history to remain in power. By applying various ethical frameworks, we can see that their behavior is not random chaos, but a predictable result of high Instrumentality (scandal pays), Moral Disengagement (ignoring consequences), and Ethical Fading (business over morals).

They demonstrate that if the rewards for unethical behavior are high enough and the internal culture supports it, ethical considerations are often the first casualty of success. The family has not just survived controversy; they have engineered it into a sustainable, albeit ethically dubious, business model.

References

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